I spent the next four months on a well-deserved holiday. Yet, I was still concerned about the nature of my job. The salary that Kairon Sahib had offered was more than double the amount I was getting in the army. And though the thought of earning more money pleased me, I was not so sure what the work involved. After all, I was a sportsman not an administrator. What did I know about a desk job?

When I joined the sports department in November 1961, I discovered that a post had been specially created for me, that of deputy director of sports. My first few weeks there, however, were a struggle and there were times when I deeply regretted my decision to leave the army. Initially, I had to commute from Delhi to Chandigarh and back again each day. I would leave Delhi at about 4 a.m. to reach office by 9, and then, after a long day, would jump into my car at 5 p.m. so that I could be home by 9.30 p.m. It was long and tedious journey, and invariably I would report to work much past the stipulated time.

I used to drive a Fiat. In those days, people had to wait for months to buy cars and scooters. But because I was ‘India’s best athlete’, Lal Bahadur Shastri, who was transport minister then, kindly allocated an ‘out-of-turn delivery’ for me. I had bought the car for five thousand rupees in 1958 with the help of money I had won as an incentive. I was at the Tokyo Asiad, when the Maharaja of Patiala, Yadavindra Singh, challenged me, saying, ‘If you beat Abdul Khaliq in the 200-metre race, I will give you five thousand rupees.’ I did, and that is how I had the money to purchase my first car—earlier I used to ride a motorcycle.

But being India’s best athlete made little difference to my working life in Chandigarh. My irregular timings had led to tension in the office, and I found it difficult to cope with the constant reprimands. More important, my long commute as well as trying to adjust to a sedentary lifestyle had left me with little time to practice, a routine that I could not afford to miss, particularly since the next event was the Jakarta Asian Games in 1962.

In frustration, I went to Kairon Sahib and complained that I was not enjoying spending my entire day doing paperwork and other administrative duties, when I should be out on the track practising. If I were still in the army I would have been exempted from military duties and allowed to spend as much time as I could on the field, practising. The chief minister severely reprimanded my senior officer. He told him that Milkha Singh was our nation’s pride and should not be restricted to the mundane routine of